

Well, I've got another one.

Salamander

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I generally choose to walk barefoot, because I like the idea that I can get my feet to become very tough and thereby win independence from shoes. Today I had walked up to the park and I was having some fun walking down the creek that runs through it. It's a great creek. The park where it is is about twenty miles from town, so the creek hasn't been fooled around with like all the ones near where I'd lived before we moved. Those creeks had been creeks only because the water had to go somewhere; otherwise, as organisms, they were dead: trickles running through dirt that had grudgingly given way to let them through, with frequent blockages to their progress that they had to go around, and all kinds of disgusting crap tossed in them. Once I saw a dead mouse; another time I discovered a rolled-up carpet discarded in the water. Generally those creeks were about eight inches across. The creek I was now walking through actually had something to it. For one thing, it was nice and broad and actually merited the name "creek". The bed was composed of rocks. In some places they were almost one flat, smooth rock, where I could walk easily so long as I kept traction on the slick moss. In other places they were all individuals, all sitting there watching what went on. I imagined some of them kind of wondered what a strange barefoot person was doing walking through their creekbed. Some of them were round, and some of them were flat. Sometimes I would stop for a while if there were lots of flat ones and a good straight area downstream and skip rocks. My personal record is sixteen. Most of the rocks were worn smooth by the water, but sometimes I would come upon big areas of rocks that had just broken off a shelf upstream and still had yet to be sanded down. A few times I've found rocks with holes in them, carved by whirlpools over several decades, if not centuries. I've saved some of those ones, but other times I let them stay where they are. Walking barefoot on rocks in the water isn't

exactly like walking through shag carpet, but I've been walking barefoot long enough that it hardly bothered me, excepting when I stepped on a particularly sharp new rock. Fortunately I also watch where I walk, so that doesn't happen often.

The rocks are of course not the only part of the creek. On the banks there's a thick bed of grass that's pleasantly overgrown, and mixed with other plants: jewelweed, poison ivy, tiger lilies, lilies-of-the-valley, those nameless plants with the thick stems that are found everywhere, and too many others to name or remember. I've seen rosebushes there sometimes, and I always judiciously stop and smell the roses. The bank is an integral part of my walk, because I very frequently walk up onto it for a change of pace or to let my feet have a break from the rock bed. It's not all covered with this luxuriant growth, however; in many places there are sycamores right up next to the water, even poking in some roots as if to sample the water before jumping in, and in other places the bank is really instead a tall cliff composed of dirt, or, more infrequently, limestone and clay. I remember one time I stopped at one of these clay cliffs and found a bunch of wet clay and for no particular reason covered my arms in it almost up to the elbows, and though I can't say why, I thought it was a neat experience to walk along waiting for it to dry. Very often I find trees fallen over the creek, at which point I simply walk over, or, if that's not plausible, I go around into the forest on the side of the creek. The forest is very nice too, just like everything around this creek—the complete immersion in very nice is what makes the creek great. The trees are tall and widely spaced, signifying that this is an old forest that hasn't been cut down yet, or, if it has, was cut down at least a hundred years ago. All in all, it's the perfect creek if you want to walk down a creek for a while. Today, though, was going to be a bit different. When I was about halfway to the place where I usually stop and turn around and go back home, I decided impulsively that I was going to keep walking as long as I wanted to. It was a good summer day, and I had nothing to do at home, and nobody was expecting me anywhere, it being the weekend.